

VIRTUE ETHICS

SOCRATES, PLATO & ARISTOTLE

Introduction to Virtue Ethics

Normative ethics is the branch of philosophy concerned with **standards for right conduct and moral evaluation**.

Unlike theories that focus solely on actions (like consequentialism or deontology), Virtue Ethics primarily focuses on **character evaluation**.

Its central question is: **"What sorts of conditions contribute to a morally good life?"** and **"What is involved in being a good or virtuous person?"**.

It delves beyond surface intuitions to explain *why* an action or character trait has a particular moral quality (e.g., rightness, virtuousness).

Core Concepts

Virtue (Aretê): A Greek term meaning "goodness" or "excellence," referring to **qualities that make someone a good and admirable person**. Examples include bravery, temperance, justice, and wisdom.

Happiness (Eudaimonia): Often translated as "flourishing," "well-being," or "living well," it represents **the ultimate good** a human being aims for.

Character: The stable dispositions and traits that define a person's moral identity. Virtues are central to developing a good character.

Practical Reason (Phronêsis): The intellectual virtue that enables a person to deliberate well about "living well as a whole" and to discern the appropriate actions in specific circumstances.

Socratic Virtue Ethics:

Socrates asked the fundamental question: **"How one ought to live?"**.He argued that we ought to **care about acquiring the virtues**.

His controversial claims include: **Knowledge is sufficient for virtue and Virtue is sufficient for happiness**.
He believed that reluctance to follow practical reason stemmed from temporary deception or ignorance, equating moral error with intellectual error.

Platonic Virtue Ethics:

Plato agreed with Socrates on the importance of defining virtues as **"forms"** (universal properties). However, he **rejected Socrates' claims** that knowledge alone is sufficient for virtue and that virtue alone guarantees happiness.

For Plato, virtue requires the **cooperation of the rational and non-rational parts of the soul** (reason, spirit, appetite).He argued that **virtue is beneficial for the agent's own happiness**, as it involves a well-ordered soul, with reason controlling non-rational desires.

Aristotelian Virtue Ethics:

Aristotle (student of Plato) largely agreed that virtue involves the **cooperation of rational and non-rational parts of the soul**, and that the virtuous person is always better off, though **virtue alone is not sufficient for complete happiness/ eudaimonia.**

Happiness (Eudaimonia) is defined as **activity that exercises practical reason well**, in accordance with **complete virtue** over a full life.

Virtue of Character is a **state** involving **election** (choice), lying in a **mean** (relative to the individual), and defined by **reason (prudence)**. The "mean" is not mediocrity, but the appropriate response in a given situation.

Virtuous actions are chosen **"for the sake of the fine (kalon)"**, which promotes a **common good**, not just the agent's self-interest.He distinguished between acting in a virtuous way and being a virtuous person, emphasizing that a virtuous person acts *from* the right state of character and for the right reasons.

Prudence (Phronêsis) is essential; it guides deliberation about the good life as a whole and about particular actions.

SUMMARY:

Virtue ethics is a normative ethical approach that primarily focuses on the **character of the moral agent** rather than simply the rightness of actions or their consequences. It asks, "**What sort of person should I be?**".

- A **right action** is understood as the action that a **virtuous person would characteristically perform** in the circumstances

The tradition begins with **Socrates** asking "how one ought to live", arguing virtue is necessary and sufficient for happiness.

- **Plato** agreed on the virtuous life as the best, emphasising how virtues contribute to a well-ordered soul, integrating rational and non-rational desires.
- **Aristotle** defined a virtue of character as "a state involving election, lying in a mean that is relative to us, defined by reason, as the prudent person would define it". He argued virtues aim at the common good, displaying an unselfish and impartial outlook characteristic of morality.
- **Stoics** identified happiness with virtue, viewing it as the only good and sufficient for happiness.
- **Aquinas** integrated Aristotelian ethics, holding that moral virtues partially constitute happiness and that natural law requires social virtues for the common good.

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